



# Eye Pain

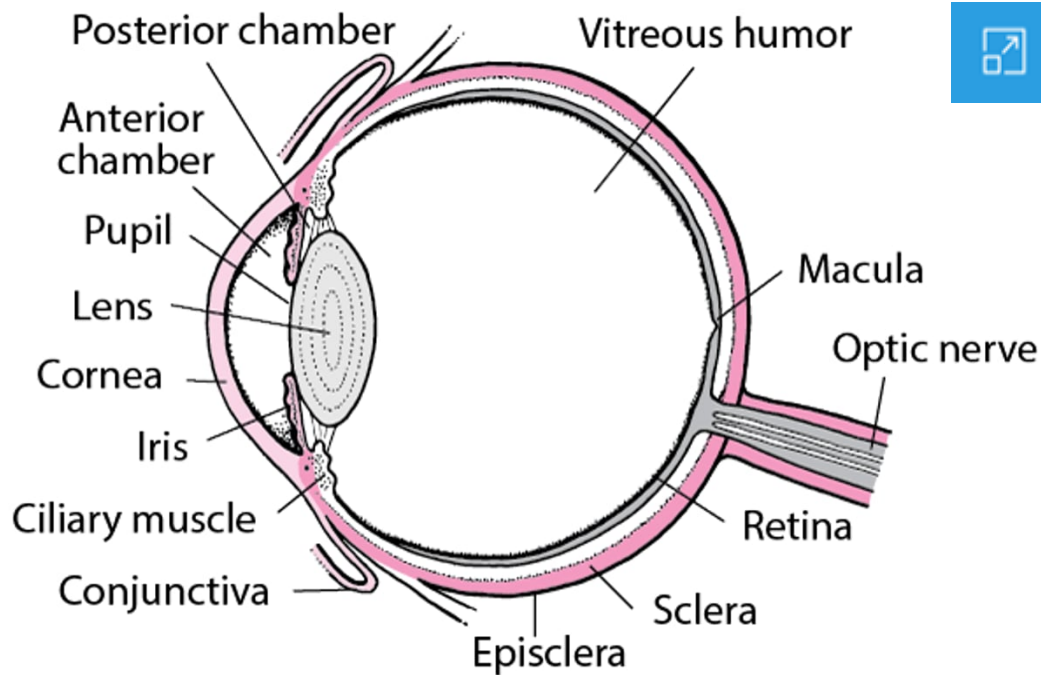
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Eye pain may be severe and seem sharp, aching, or throbbing, or people may feel only mild irritation of the eye surface or the sensation of a foreign object in the eye. Many causes of eye pain also cause **the eye to look red**. Other symptoms may be present depending on the cause of eye pain. For example, people may have **blurred vision**, a **bulging eye**, or pain worsened by bright light.

The cornea (the clear layer in front of the iris and pupil) is highly sensitive to pain. Many disorders that affect the cornea also affect the anterior chamber (the fluid-filled space between the iris and the inner part of the cornea) and cause spasm of the muscle that controls the iris (the ciliary muscle). When such spasm is present, bright light causes muscle contraction and worsening pain.

## An Inside Look at the Eye



## Causes of Eye Pain

Disorders that cause eye pain can be divided into disorders that affect primarily the cornea, disorders of other parts of the eye, and disorders of other areas of the body that cause pain to be felt in the eye.

### Common causes

Corneal disorders are the most common causes of eye pain overall, particularly:

- Corneal scratches (corneal abrasions)
- Foreign objects

However, most corneal disorders can cause eye pain.

A feeling of scratchiness or a foreign body sensation may be caused by a disorder of the conjunctiva (the thin membrane that lines the eyelid and covers the front of the eye) or of the cornea.



## Some Causes and Features of Eye Pain

| Cause                                                                                                                                                        | Common Features*                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | Diagnostic Approach                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Disorders that affect the cornea primarily                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                           |
| Contact lens keratitis (inflammation of the cornea—the clear layer in front of the iris and pupil—caused by wearing contact lenses for long periods of time) | <p>Usually affecting both eyes</p> <p>Eye ache and a feeling of grittiness in the eye</p> <p>Eye redness, tearing, and sensitivity to light</p> <p>In people who wear contact lenses for long periods of time</p>                                                                                   | A doctor's examination                                                                                    |
| <p><u>Corneal scratch</u> (abrasion)</p> <p><u>A foreign object</u> (body)</p>                                                                               | <p>Symptoms that begin after an eye injury or high-risk activity (for example, grinding metal), which may not be noticed in infants and young children</p> <p>Pain in the affected eye when blinking and a foreign body sensation</p> <p>Eye redness, tearing, and usually sensitivity to light</p> | A doctor's examination                                                                                    |
| <u>Corneal ulcer</u>                                                                                                                                         | <p>Often a grayish patch on the cornea that later becomes an open, painful sore</p> <p>Eye ache and a foreign body sensation</p>                                                                                                                                                                    | <p>A doctor's examination</p> <p>Culture of a sample taken from the ulcer, done by an ophthalmologist</p> |



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